

BACK ON TRACK Maldives president Mohamed Muizzu and S. Jaishankar in Male, Aug. 10

A STEADY HAND

Most agree that ties with neighbours are improving, but rising Pakistan-sponsored terrorism causes concern

By **PRADIP R. SAGAR**

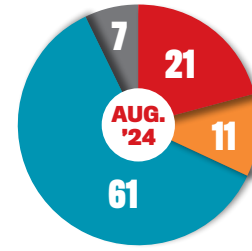
Maintaining ties with neighbouring countries was the chief thrust of India's foreign policy in the past six months. External affairs minister S. Jaishankar visited the Maldives from August 9-11 in the first high-level Indian visit since President Mohamed Muizzu came to power last year on an 'India out' plank. Naturally, ties have been strained as Male inches closer to China's orbit. However, the damaged relations seem to be on the mend—during Jaishankar's visit, Muizzu expressed gratitude for India's long-term support and affirmed the Maldives' commitment to strengthening ties.

Also in early August, foreign secretary Vikram Misri was in Nepal to further consolidate relations. Ties with Sri Lanka are back on track too. Similarly, Bhutan and Myanmar are standing by New Delhi despite Beijing's attempt to woo them. Ties with Bangladesh—where in early August the Sheikh Hasina government was ousted by popular protests—are at a crucial juncture. India has expressed hope that democratic polls would be held soon, and Mohammad Yunus, the chief of the interim government, has assured New Delhi that attacks on Hindus and other minorities would be curbed.

Taking note of all this, almost 61 per cent of the respondents in the India Today Mood of the Nation (MOTN) August 2024 poll agree that India's ties with neighbours have improved. A total of 31.5 per cent feel relations have deteriorated; 10.5 per cent of them say that though ties with neighbours have deteriorated, it does not matter.

Relatively tranquil till recently, India's Jammu division is in the throes of a deadly spike in Pakistan-sponsored terrorist incidents. Of the 120 security personnel who lost their lives in J&K fighting terrorism, over 50 died in Jammu. Though Islamabad periodically makes the right noises about peace, New Delhi has been firm in its stand: terror and talks cannot go together. Over 51 per cent of the MOTN respondents have suggested putting diplomatic pressure on Islamabad to reduce terrorism. However, 17.5 per cent believe in going to war to teach Pakistan a lesson, while over 15 per cent say a repeat of the 2016 surgical strike targeting terror camps inside Pakistan is required. ■

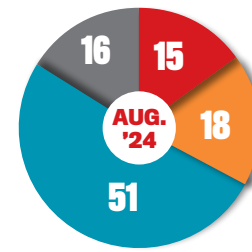
Q. How do you think India's relationship with neighbours has been in recent times?



It has deteriorated and it's worrisome | It has deteriorated but it doesn't matter | It has improved | DK/ CS

The government has done well, say most, but a significant minority differs

Q. Following the recent terror attacks in J&K, how should India deal with Pakistan?



Do a surgical strike | Go to war with Pakistan | Use diplomatic options to put pressure on Pakistan | DK/ CS

Though most still prefer the diplomatic route, over 30% want hard action

DK/ CS: Don't know/ can't say
All figures in % and rounded off